



Plants for rock gardens

Rock features are normally associated with sunny sites, but a surprising number of alpine and low-growing plants will thrive in some shade.

Most alpine plants require a few hours of sun each day and may not flower if left to languish in deep shade, so site your rock garden carefully. You can maintain year-round color and interest with a succession of seasonal displays, starting in spring with a range of bulbs and progressing into early summer with early-flowering perennials, such as fawn lily, columbine, and bleeding heart. Midsummer highlights include sweet woodruff and lady's mantle. The striking red berries of wintergreen pops against leathery foliage, while other evergreens like juniper and hebe provide additional color and interest in the winter months.



BULB MEDIUM

Allium schoenoprasum

CHIVES A clump-forming, upright perennial bulb with narrow, hollow, dark green edible leaves. In spring, it produces fluffy, pale purple pompomlike flower heads. It is ideal for rock gardens; plant in dappled shade.

↑12in (30cm)

☞ Z4–8



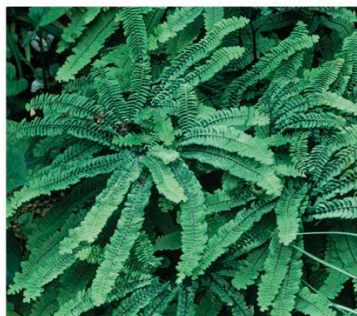
PERENNIAL SMALL

Anemone blanda

GRECIAN WINDFLOWER This perennial corm produces divided leaves and blue, pink, or white in early spring. Varieties include 'Violet Star' (above), which has amethyst-violet flowers. Plant the tubers in fall where they will receive some sun.

↑↔6in (15cm)

☞ ! Z5–8



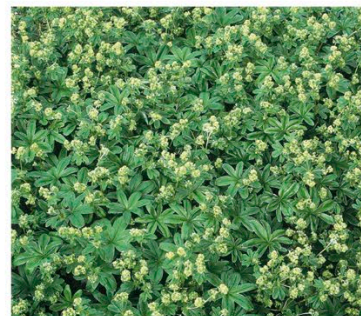
PERENNIAL SMALL

Adiantum aleuticum

WESTERN MAIDENHAIR FERN A compact deciduous or semievergreen fern with pale green fronds divided into oblong segments. Ideal for rock gardens with rich soil. The dwarf form 'Subpumilum' has black stalks and fronds with overlapping segments.

↑↔18in (45cm)

☞ Z3–8 (N)



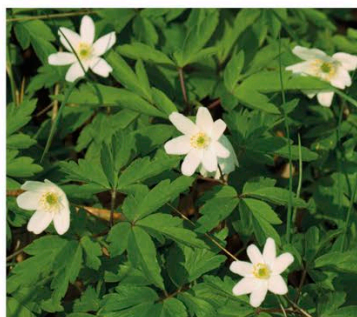
PERENNIAL SMALL

Alchemilla alpina

ALPINE LADY'S MANTLE This mound-forming perennial has lobed, white-edged green leaves that are silky-haired beneath. Spikes of tiny greenish yellow flowers with larger green outer petals appear in summer. Trim untidy foliage. Avoid dry soils.

↑6in (15cm) ↔24in (60cm) or more

☞ Z3–7



PERENNIAL SMALL

Anemone nemorosa

WOOD ANEMONE This dwarf perennial has deeply cut midgreen leaves. From spring to early summer, a profusion of yellow-eyed white daisy-like flowers appears. Plant it in groups at the front of a partly shaded rock garden.

↑6in (15cm) ↔12in (30cm)

☞ ! Z4–8



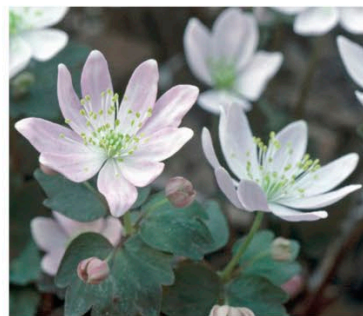
PERENNIAL SMALL

Anemone sylvestris

SNOWDROP WINDFLOWER This dwarf perennial has divided midgreen leaves. From spring to early summer, it produces fragrant, bowl-shaped white flowers with yellow centers. It prefers neutral to alkaline soil; can be aggressive.

↑↔12in (30cm)

☞ ! Z3–8



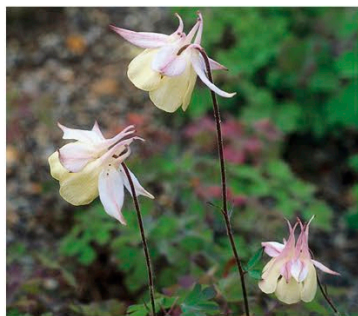
PERENNIAL SMALL

Anemonella thalictroides

RUE ANEMONE A dwarf perennial with dark blue-green leaves divided into rounded leaflets. From spring to early summer, it produces cup-shaped white or pink blooms. Grow it at the front of a rock garden in a sheltered spot.

↑4in (10cm) ↔1½in (4cm) or more

☞ Z4–7 (N)



PERENNIAL SMALL

Aquilegia fragrans

FRAGRANT COLUMBINE This upright perennial has finely cut bluish green leaves and nodding, bell-shaped, fragrant creamy white flowers with bluish- or pinkish white outer sepals in summer. Deadhead spent blooms to prevent excessive self-seeding.

↑16in (40cm) ↔8in (20cm)

☞ Z5–8



PERENNIAL SMALL

Asperula arcadiensis

ARCADIAN WOODRUFF This clump-forming perennial makes a mound of loose stems with tiny, hairy gray leaves. It bears tiny, pale pink tubular flowers in early summer. Dislikes wet winter soils and is best planted in gritty, free-draining soil.

↑3in (8cm) ↔12in (30cm)

☞ Z5–7



PERENNIAL SMALL

Campanula trachelium

RAINER'S HAREBELL A ground cover perennial with oval, toothed-edged gray-green leaves. Pale lavender bell-shaped flowers appear in summer. Allow it to spread over the rocks in areas where it will receive some sun during the day.

↑3in (8cm) ↔8in (20cm)

☞ Z5–7